

Editorial Writing

Invitational A Meet • 2026



You are a reporter for the **Leaguetown Press**, the student newspaper of Leaguetown High School. From the given information, write an **editorial** as you would for the high school newspaper.

Remember that as an editorial writer, you should **support or oppose** policy or action; you should not sermonize. You have **45 minutes**.

Do not write your name or the name of your school on this sheet or your entry. **Put your number on your paper.**

Leaguetown High School has 2,310 students enrolled in grades 9-12. Last week, the district placed cafeteria worker Shelby Parkman on leave without pay pending an investigation after Principal Esther Rosales discovered Parkman had been collecting donations to help cover the cost of lunch for students with low account balances.

At the beginning of the year, qualified students could enroll in a free-and-reduced price lunch program. The district has a policy published in the student handbook against personnel conducting private fundraising for students. District administrators had previously reprimanded Parkman for a similar incident involving fundraising for student lunches.

An anonymous community member sent screenshots to Rosales of multiple posts from Parkman's personal Facebook page, including links to a GoFundMe that had raised more than \$850 in two weeks. Parkman was immediately placed on leave pending an investigation.

Since she was put on leave, a petition has circulated on social media with parents and students asking for Parkman to be reinstated. It has more than 450 signatures.

The school board will conduct a hearing in executive session on Jan. 15 to discuss findings of the investigation and determine whether Parkman will be reinstated or if her employment will be terminated. You are writing for the issue of the Press to be distributed Wednesday, Jan. 14.

THOSE SUPPORTING PARKMAN'S REINSTATEMENT

The fact that Parkman was raising money on her personal time on her personal social media accounts to pay for student lunches only demonstrates how big her heart is. What people choose to do with their personal time and money is not the district's business. She has been employed with the district for 15 years with no other issues and is by all accounts a hard worker. An employee should not lose his or her job for trying to do something kind for a student.

THOSE OPPOSING PARKMAN'S REINSTATEMENT

If a student is unable to purchase lunch, the school does not leave them hungry. In addition to the free-and-reduced-price lunch program, there are lunches available for students who are unable to pay. Parkman acknowledged the employee handbook at the beginning of the year, which clearly stated the rules for fundraising for students. In addition, administrators have already had to reprimand her for doing this once. An employee who can't follow simple rules after a warning should not be working for the district.

■ SHELBY PARKMAN, cafeteria worker

“When a child gets to my register with a sandwich and a piece of fruit or even just a bag of chips and they realize they don’t have any money in their account, I panic. I can’t take the food from them. I don’t want to embarrass anyone, and I don’t want them to be hungry during class. A few years ago, I started just paying for a lunch here and there on my own, but that got expensive fast. Then I sent around an envelope to take up a collection from teachers. Then I’d keep the envelope on me during lunch. If a kid couldn’t pay, I’d just grab a few bucks from the collection to cover it. Apparently, that was a no-no because I got written up for student fundraising.

“A few weeks ago, this kid I really love came through the line. She didn’t have any money, and her account was empty. I had to take her lunch and send her to grab the free cheese sandwich. I could see the tears coming up in her eyes. I told myself that was the last time I’d do that. I created a GoFundMe the next day, with plans to donate the money to Ms. Rosales, so she could take it through the proper channels or through the nutrition services department. I thought they could add money to each student’s account if it was running low. I thought this way, it would be more appropriate. I’ve been here for 15 years, but maybe I should be fired. Maybe I should find another job in a district that cares about kids getting a proper lunch or a district that takes better care of its employees.”

■ ESTHER ROSALES, principal

“It seems like Ms. Parkman was doing the wrong thing for the right reasons. We have rules against private fundraising because there is no accountability in a situation like this. We have one person deciding which students get extra money for their lunches. That’s not fair to all students. We have a district employee soliciting money from community members online. We have no idea if those donors know where their money is going. We have no means to ensure that the money goes to students. What if Ms. Parkman decided a student deserved new art supplies and decided to donate it to that student instead? We have too many ‘what ifs’ to allow these types of activities with our employees.

“That being said, we take student nutrition extremely seriously. Students who meet the criteria can have their parents enroll them in our free-and-reduced-priced meal program. Those students receive free or discounted breakfast and lunch every day. Our students need to go through those proper channels to receive those services from the district. Students who do not meet the criteria and are still struggling with hunger should visit their counselors.”

■ MICHAEL ROJAS, sophomore

“I came through the lunch line once last year and realized my account was empty, and I didn’t have any cash. It wasn’t a big deal. My parents normally give me plenty of money, but I think they just forgot this time. Ms. Parkman didn’t hesitate. She just reached into an envelope and said it’s taken care of this time. She didn’t have to do that, but it was really nice. The more I think about it, I’m sure there are kids who end up in that spot every day. It’s nice to know we have people like Ms. Parkman in the cafeteria to make sure each kid can eat without fear of embarrassment.”

■ ADDITIONAL INFORMATION

The federal government provides reimbursements for the free-and-reduced-priced meal program through the Texas Department of Agriculture.

DO NOT PASS OUT TO STUDENTS BEFORE OR DURING THE CONTEST

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Editorial Writing Contest Tips and Sample Stories

Contest Director: Give one copy to each judge to use during critiquing/judging. Also, staple one copy of the contest and one copy of the contest tips to each student's returned entry. The purpose of the tips is to provide immediate feedback to students. However, it is not meant to replace written comments from the judge.

1. Lead with a statement of the situation and then take a clear, definitive staff stance. The situation is whether the district will reinstate the employment of a cafeteria worker who was privately fundraising to pay for student lunches.
2. As a general rule, use third person. If you must use a pronoun, use first person plural (we, meaning "we, the newspaper staff"). Do not use first person singular (I, me, mine) or second person (you). Avoid unnecessary use of pronouns. Rather than "We believe the district should..." write instead, "The district should..."
3. Don't waddle into the editorial. Get right to the point and, as a general rule, don't ask questions. An editorial should answer questions, not ask them. Above all, remember that your purpose is to make thoughtful, logical arguments in support of your position, not to engage in a tirade. The editorial should not be long — 450 words at the most. Although it's not recommended all the time, sometimes a writer could use a feature opening to grab the reader's attention and draw the reader into the story.
4. Look for the future angle. Your paper comes out before the disciplinary committee meeting.
5. Once you've stated your position/stance, the body of the editorial should support your stance and refute the opposition.
6. After the body of your editorial, complete the editorial with a specific solution.
7. Avoid direct quotes. You can pull information from these quotes, as has been done here, but it's not necessary to attribute that information unless the person has substantial credibility.
8. Watch for factual errors. Pay attention to minor details. Also, stay focused.
9. Don't clutter up the editorial with clichés or trite phrases such as "adults don't understand teens" or any variation thereof. Also, edit out the name of the school unless it is necessary for clarity. It isn't necessary to say "Leaguetown Independent School District" or "Leaguetown High School." Students know the name of the school. They don't need to be reminded.

SAMPLE EDITORIAL/SUPPORTING PARKMAN'S REINSTATEMENT

A cafeteria worker hopes to have her job reinstated tomorrow after she violated a student fundraiser rule. The school board will meet in executive session to determine if her employment should be terminated.

Following Principal Esther Rosales' discovery that the worker had been collecting donations to cover the cost of lunches for students with low account balances, the district placed cafeteria worker Shelby Parkman on unpaid leave.

The district should reinstate Parkman's employment and allow her to return to work.

Parkman has been a dedicated employee for 15 years, and it would be cruel to fire her for extending kindness to students. Furthermore, firing her would demonstrate a lack of concern for the well-being of students on the district's part. After all, lunchtime hunger is not a new issue. Parents often forget to replenish their students' account balances, or families have financial troubles that arise unexpectedly.

Parkman acted out of the genuine fear that kids would go hungry or feel embarrassed in front of their peers for not being able to pay for their meals. She broke the rules, but her intentions were not malicious. Administrators should not forget that.

Rosales believes that the problem with private fundraising is that one person decides which students are deserving of extra lunch money. She thinks this leads to inequity. However, Parkman's plan was to possibly give the donations to the nutrition services department, so that they could fairly allocate the money across the students' accounts.

When the district makes its decision, it should consider the real-life impact of the employee's actions. By taking the time to create a GoFundMe, Parkman was ensuring that every student received a proper lunch. The district should commend her selflessness and reinstate her employment in the school cafeteria.

SAMPLE EDITORIAL/OPPOSING PARKMAN'S REINSTATEMENT

A cafeteria worker hopes to have her job reinstated tomorrow after she violated a student fundraiser rule. The school board will meet in executive session to determine if her employment should be terminated.

Following Principal Esther Rosales' discovery that the worker had been collecting donations to cover the cost of lunches for students with low account balances, the district placed cafeteria worker Shelby Parkman on unpaid leave.

The district should not reinstate Parkman, and her employment should be officially terminated.

This is not the first time that the district has had to reprimand Parkman for disobeying district policy. In the past, she was written up for using her own funds and donations from teachers to pay for meals. Instead of learning from those mistakes, Parkman collected money from the community. Unfortunately, those donors have no way of ensuring that their money is going to students. Once they donate, control over that money is delegated to the initial recipient. This is the problem with private fundraising. Even if the recipient has good intent, one person decides which students are deserving of extra lunch money. This is inequitable.

Those supporting Parkman's actions believe that her private fundraising efforts outweigh the district's initiatives to ensure that students never go hungry. However, the district has implemented free-and-reduced-price meal programs for students who need financial assistance. If these students simply went through the proper channels, they would never find themselves in a situation where they needed to take funds from community members online.

While her intentions were pure, Parkman broke a district rule, and it is not the first time that she has done so. The district should terminate her employment to ensure fairness for all students and to show other district employees that they must follow proper rules and procedures.